TRANSMISSION TANGLE

ing over 1,000 bighas (330 acres) of fertile mango and litchi orchards.

According to local block development officer (BDO) Junaid Ahmed, the transmission lines travel the entire width of Farakka block and touch a fragment of Malda district's Kaliachak before entering Bangladesh. Land for six towers, each covering 16 cottahs (11,520 square feet), has been purchased by the Adani Group. Ahmed says 21 towers in all are to be installed for the project.

Villagers say they were kept in the dark about the sale. "The company was secretive; pamphlets in Hindi and English told us about transmission lines, not that they would ruin our orchards and livelihood. We were made to sign on them forcefully for compensation as little as Rs 1.5 lakh to Rs 4 lakh a cottah (720 sq feet)," says Sufiyan of Dadontola village. Masiur Rahaman, who got Rs 1.4 lakh a cottah for parting with a 25-cottah plot, alleges that resistance by villagers was met with intimidation. "Many of my friends were jailed, indicted on false charges of vandalising temples," he adds. The farmers have formed a resistance platform against land acquisition; a committee—Jomi Jiban Jibika Prakriti Loot Birodhi Janaganer Committee (people's committee for resisting the loot of land, nature, life and livelihood)—has been set up too.

Worryingly for the Trinamool Congress, all this has echoes of the Singur and Nandigram movements it supported, where people's resistance struggles triumphed against the forcible state acquisition of land for industry—it was the Left regime in the crosshairs then.

This time, in June 2022, six months before the Hindenburg brouhaha and unbeknownst to the world of global finance and its watchdogs, the villagers of Dadontola, Ghola-Kandi, Samaspur, Imamnagar North and South and Ballarpur had erupted in protests against the installation of the high-tension lines. The administration had retaliated with an iron hand. On June 22, curfew was imposed in the affected areas of Farakka block. On July 2, a contingent of 800 police personnel was deployed to quell a demonstration at an installation site. The protesters, including women, were mercilessly beaten up. Many

ELECTRIC EXPRESS





FRIENDS ONCE
Mamata Banerjee with Gautam Adani in Kolkata, Apr. 2022

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